

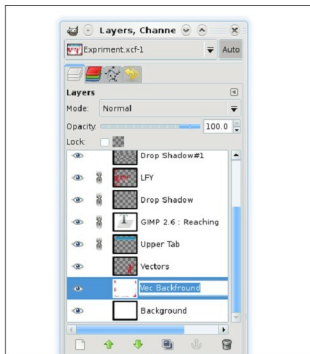


Figure 6: Managing layers

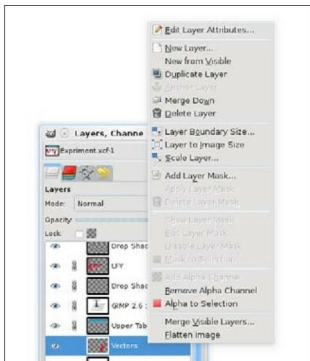


Figure 7: Layer editing options

the mask, so make sure you delete it before applying.

- **Show Layer Mask:** Lists the changes done in the mask applied.
- **Edit Layer Mask:** This option is selected by default if you have added a layer mask. It's nothing but a selection to the mask preview. You can easily switch between the layer and its mask by either using this option or clicking on the preview.
- **Mask to Selection:** Makes an active selection to all the editing/painting done on the mask layer.
- **Add Alpha Channel:** This option makes a non-transparent layer capable of handling transparency, though it does not make it transparent. It is a very handy tool for creating quick animation with the GIMP.
- **Alpha to Selection:** This option makes an active selection on the drawing done on layers. It makes the drawing active—not the layer. So if you want to edit things later on, this tool comes as a saviour.
- **Merge Visible Layer:** Merges all the active visible parts of a layer, in the image.

- **Flatten Image:** It's a unique case of the merge layer. It merges all the visible parts of the layer, deletes all the non-visible parts of the layers, removes the transparency and fills it with background colour, turning all the layers into one single image leaving no alpha channel behind. This is usually done when saving an image with a JPEG extension.

That's it for now. I have tried to cover almost every aspect of layers—hope they're now a bit easier to work with. You don't need to grasp these things—just go through them once, fiddle around a bit and you are ready to get started. The dull days are about to end, as we will learn to work with tools in our next assignment. So stay tuned for the next tutorial and till then, happy GIMPing! 

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The author is a FOSS/hardware enthusiast who likes to review software and tweak his hardware for optimum performance. He is interested in Python/Qt programming and fond of benchmarking the latest distros and applications.

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